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A quick dive into ECMAScript 6 – the Future of JavaScript

>>With the hype around HTML5 waning, ECMAScript 6 is what all the cool kids are talking about these days, let's find out why>

The web is a confusing and beautiful mess, and a central part of that is its scripting language, JavaScript. It is the only programming language that is native to the web, and can run directly in any browser.

What this means is that the capabilities of the web are closely tied to the capabilities of JavaScript and likewise the productivity of working on web apps is tied to how productive JavaScript is.

With the push for HTML5, JavaScript now has a larger surface area of features to work with. It can work with 3D objects using WebGL, it has a rich 2D API using the HTML5 canvas. There is video, audio, WebRTC for real time communication, and a whole lot more.

However, there are many convenient features that are still missing from JavaScript that developers have been clamouring for. This is where the latest ECMAScript 6 standard comes in.

If you're wondering where ECMAScript comes in when we are talking about JavaScript, let's take a quick look at the history of the language to understand this mess.

A Brief History

JavaScript has been around for a long time, this is in fact the 20th year of its existence. Back when it was conceived, it was no different

that something like Flash or Silverlight, i.e. a proprietary solution offered by a single vendor to differentiate their product. It showed up in Netscape Navigator 2.0 and drove Microsoft to create its own scripting language JScript that was compatible with JavaScript.



To make sure that the web didn't end up with a dozen splintered, and slightly different dialects of the same scripting language, JavaScript was soon standardised by Ecma International

(European Computer Manufacturers Association) a standards organisation. This standard is what is known as ECMAScript. JavaScript is thus an implementation of the ECMAScript standard.

The specification for all revisions of ECMAScript can be downloaded from the Ecma website: <http://www.ecma-international.org/>

The ECMAScript standard went through many revisions, notably ECMAScript 3 was the first somewhat major update to the language. ECMAScript 4 was supposed to be an even more ambitious update to the language with the addition of a type system, modules, classes and a lot more. ECMAScript 4 was abandoned and the language moved to a different direction with ECMAScript 5. If

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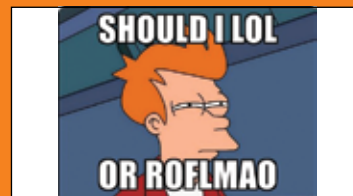
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